

25 The passive in the past

English uses the passive voice in the past to stress the effect of an action that happened in the past, rather than the cause of that action.

See also:

Past simple **7** Past continuous **10**

Present perfect **11** Past perfect **13**

25.1 THE PAST SIMPLE PASSIVE

The past simple passive is used when referring to a single completed action in the past, focusing on the effect rather than the cause.



PAST SIMPLE

The fire **destroyed** the buildings.

PAST SIMPLE PASSIVE

The buildings **were destroyed** by the fire.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

The trees **were cut down** last year.



The rail road **was damaged** during the storm.



Two people **were injured** in the accident.



HOW TO FORM

SUBJECT

"WAS / WERE"

PAST PARTICIPLE

REST OF SENTENCE

The buildings

were

destroyed

in a fire.

The thing that receives the action.

"Was" is for singular subjects, and "were" is for plural subjects.

The main verb is a past participle.